



BACK *to* BETH *and* PENNY

Beth's situation also showed a lack of foresight, but the roots of her debt problem actually began in her childhood, after her father's death. Prior to that sad event, the family had been modest but comfortable, and the daughters didn't have to think about whether or not they could afford something. But then her mother had to work to support the family, something she had not been prepared to do.

Beth and her sister loved their mother and did not really mind helping her in the catering business. But seeds of discontent began to grow in Beth as she could no longer have the new clothes or other amenities she had been used to and that her friends still enjoyed. By the time she was an adult, she was tired of denying herself. Having seen her mother go from being a content homemaker to struggling to support a family, Beth prepared for a satisfying career in order to be able to support herself whether or not she later married. She succeeded professionally, but failed to plan for much beyond today—she used credit to purchase what she